

## *Lopez Beltran visa dispute puts Sheinbaum in a bind*

送信者: EG Mexico 受信日時: 2026-08-15 05:46

### 【メール原文】

Visa revocations will continue to put pressure on Sheinbaum. The State Department's cancellation of Lopez Beltran's visa adds to a growing list of Mor|||||||||||||

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Sheinbaum's de-escalation options narrow as Washington targets Lopez Obrador's son

14 Aug 2026 16:40 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

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The US's move to revoke the visa of former president Andres Manuel Lopez Obrador's son comes close to crossing President Claudia Sheinbaum's red lines and will increase pressure from her political base to respond more decisively.

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Sheinbaum will seek to maintain security cooperation with the US while taking a firm public stance in support of Andres Lopez Beltran, who issued a fiery letter addressed to President Donald Trump that is likely to anger Washington.

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Trade discussions will remain on a separate track for now, but the US will continue to press Sheinbaum on security given ongoing concerns about alleged ties between high-profile Morena figures and criminal groups.

Visa revocations will continue to put pressure on Sheinbaum. The State Department's cancellation of Lopez Beltran's visa adds to a growing list of Morena-linked figures targeted by Washington. Media reports indicate that Washington has revoked or threatened to cancel visas for up to 50 prominent Mexican public officials, including governors; the US is increasingly likely to follow through on these threats as Sheinbaum denounces such actions publicly.

Lopez Beltran's confrontational letter to Trump likely to deepen tensions. Before the news broke, Lopez Beltran released a letter to the US president in which he sharply criticized the State Department. The letter fits a broader Morena strategy that portrays US pressure as an attack on Mexican sovereignty; it echoes Sheinbaum's public position but risks provoking further escalation due to its harsh rhetoric.

Sheinbaum probably did not approve the letter's exact wording or release, and she avoided endorsing Lopez Beltran's specific attacks on Secretary of State Marco Rubio. Even so, its confrontational tone strains the relationship at a moment when she sought to manage tensions through calibrated concessions rather than public confrontation. Further escalation could include Washington publicly disclosing the reasons behind the visa revocation, issuing new indictments against Morena officials, or ramping up other unilateral actions through US security agencies.

Support for Lopez Beltran sends signal that any move against his father is off limits. Sheinbaum has strong incentives to publicly support Lopez Beltran to preserve unity within Morena and to indicate to Washington that any move against the former president is out of bounds. Any US action targeting Lopez

Obrador himself remains one of Sheinbaum's clearest red lines.

Unlike earlier indictments and visa cancellations, which she could reframe or downplay, a direct move against Lopez Obrador would be impossible to present as anything other than a hostile act. Such a step would also risk a broader rupture in security cooperation. The move against Lopez Beltran is consistent with Eurasia Group's view that Washington would escalate pressure, but it still falls short of an indictment or formal investigation into Lopez Obrador or his family, thereby testing Sheinbaum's reddest line without yet crossing it (see: Sheinbaum's pushback threatens breakdown in security ties , 15 June 2026).

US will continue pressure to intensify action against criminal groups and Morena figures. Washington's pressure campaign is unfolding on parallel tracks. On one track, cooperation is producing concrete results, including the recent suspension and partial reinstatement of US Department of Agriculture avocado inspections in the state of Michoacan. The inspections were linked to extortion networks targeting avocado exporters and helped prompt Mexican authorities to arrest a dozen suspects tied to the Jalisco New Generation Cartel, including high-priority US targets. Those arrests were further reinforced by joint US-Mexico action against money-laundering and weapons-trafficking networks.

On the other track, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Drug Enforcement Administration Administrator Terry Cole have increased calls for more forceful action against criminal groups on the ground. Additionally, with Todd Blanche's recent confirmation as attorney general there will be less consideration in Washington about the second-order effects of aggressive measures. Sheinbaum will continue accepting pressure from US security agencies for more proactive targeting of high- and mid-level criminals, as well as money-laundering operations, while rejecting any suggestion of a US operational presence in Mexico.

Recent successes have done little to address Washington's core complaint: that Morena officials maintain ties to criminal groups. Sheinbaum's unwillingness to act against implicated allies and her public defense of Lopez Beltran will probably reinforce US perceptions that she prioritizes party unity over accountability. That dynamic will likely lead to greater US pressure and increase the likelihood of unilateral US actions such as indictments, sanctions, and more assertive actions by US intelligence personnel.

Trade discussions will continue on a separate track, with their own pressure points. Even as security tensions escalate, the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA) review is advancing with a distinct set of frictions. A pending Section 301 determination on structural manufacturing overcapacity could produce new US tariffs on Mexican goods. Washington will also keep pressing Mexico over transshipment from China. Other unresolved disputes include sectoral tariffs, as well as pressure to tighten automotive rules of origin. Those frictions will keep the fourth round of negotiations contentious, but the talks will remain rooted in trade disputes rather than security issues.

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